



Critical Summary Practice: Listening into Writing

Tasks

1. What are the strengths and weaknesses of each sample?
2. Which sample is closest to your own summary?
3. Underline any useful language

Sample A

The speaker talks about smartphone addiction and says it is a serious problem in modern society. He explains that smartphones are addictive because they release dopamine and make people want to keep using them. He also says that many people use smartphones too much and that this leads to problems such as depression, anxiety and suicide.

The speaker believes that smartphones are worse than smoking because more people use them. He says phones are changing children's brains and making them less creative and less productive. The speaker suggests that parents should limit screen time and take phones away at night. He also believes technology companies should be blamed for creating addictive products. Finally, he says people need to spend less time on phones and improve their mental health.

I agree with the speaker because smartphones clearly cause many social problems. Most people would probably be happier if they spent less time online. (174 words)



Sample B

The speaker argues that smartphone addiction should be recognised as a major public health issue. Drawing on his experience in child and adolescent psychiatry, he explains that smartphones activate dopamine-based reward systems, creating behaviours that resemble other forms of addiction. He identifies symptoms such as cravings, withdrawal, increasing tolerance and unsuccessful attempts to reduce use. The speaker also notes that smartphone addiction is not formally recognised in major diagnostic frameworks, making it difficult to diagnose and treat.

Furthermore, he describes smartphones as a “super addiction” because they combine a range of potentially addictive activities within a single device. According to the speaker, excessive smartphone use is associated with problems such as depression, anxiety, cyberbullying and declining academic performance. Particular concern is expressed about young people because smartphone use may affect brain development and family relationships.

To address these problems, the speaker recommends limiting screen time, removing phones at night, educating children about digital addiction and encouraging adults to set positive examples. In addition, he argues that technology companies should be held accountable and that researchers should work towards establishing formal diagnostic criteria.

The lecture is interesting and makes several good points. Overall, the speaker’s argument seems convincing because he provides examples and statistics. (230 words)



Sample C

The speaker contends that smartphones have become one of the most significant causes of contemporary mental health problems. He argues that smartphones are deliberately designed to exploit psychological vulnerabilities and that they are broadly comparable to traditional addictive substances. The speaker maintains that widespread smartphone use is responsible for rising levels of depression, anxiety and social dysfunction, particularly among younger people.

A notable strength of the lecture is its focus on the mechanisms that may encourage repeated smartphone use. By explaining the role of dopamine and reward pathways, the speaker provides a plausible explanation for why many individuals find it difficult to reduce their screen time. In addition, his discussion of social pressures and online harms highlights broader consequences that extend beyond individual users.

However, some elements of the argument are less convincing. The comparison between smartphone use and substance addiction is rhetorically powerful, yet the extent to which these phenomena are truly equivalent remains open to debate. Similarly, while the speaker links smartphones to a range of mental health problems, alternative explanations receive relatively little attention. Nevertheless, the lecture succeeds in drawing attention to an issue that may require greater public scrutiny. (227 words)

Sample D

In this lecture, the speaker argues that smartphone addiction should be regarded as a serious public health concern rather than merely a lifestyle issue. Drawing on his experience as a child and adolescent psychiatry specialist, he suggests that smartphones stimulate dopamine-based reward systems in ways that encourage compulsive use. To support this claim, he identifies several indicators commonly associated with addiction, including cravings, withdrawal symptoms, escalating use and unsuccessful attempts to cut back. He also highlights the absence of smartphone addiction from major diagnostic classifications, arguing that this has hindered efforts to recognise and address the problem.

A central component of the speaker's argument is the notion that smartphones function as a "super addiction". Unlike traditional addictive products, smartphones combine numerous rewarding activities, such as social media, gaming and shopping, within a device that is constantly accessible and socially accepted. The speaker argues that this combination has contributed to unprecedented levels of adoption and may be linked to a range of mental health and social problems, including anxiety, depression, cyberbullying and disrupted family relationships. Particular concern is expressed regarding young people because excessive smartphone use may influence both social development and educational outcomes.

The lecture concludes by proposing both individual and institutional responses. At the individual level, the speaker recommends restricting screen time, reducing night-time phone use, increasing education about digital addiction and Sampling healthier behaviour. At a broader level, he advocates clearer diagnostic criteria, greater accountability for technology companies and increased collaboration between researchers and industry.

Although the argument is persuasive and logically structured, some of its strongest claims depend heavily on analogy. For instance, comparisons with tobacco and substance addiction are effective in emphasising urgency; however, they may oversimplify important differences between these issues. Nevertheless, the lecture successfully combines scientific, social and policy perspectives, making a



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compelling case that problematic smartphone use deserves greater attention from both individuals and institutions. (337 words)



General Notes

- A has some basic understanding but misses key points and overgeneralises.
- B is accurate and comprehensive but mainly descriptive.
- C is evaluative and academically written but incomplete as a listening summary.
- D is accurate, coherent and critically balanced.

Useful Language for Critical Summaries

Function	Useful language
Reporting the argument	The speaker argues that...; The lecture suggests that...; A central point is that...
Adding key points	Furthermore,...; In addition,...; Another important aspect of the argument is...
Evaluating cautiously	This is persuasive because...; However, this claim may...; The comparison is effective, although...
Avoiding overstatement	may contribute to; appears to rely on; is associated with; could be interpreted as
Concluding critically	Overall, the lecture is effective in...; Nevertheless, the argument would be stronger if...



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